

Education Indicator

EDUCATION AND LEARNING OUTCOMES

School leavers with NCEA Level 3 or above

In 2024, 56 percent of school leavers achieved NCEA Level 3 or above. This is an increase of 2.7 percentage points from 2023.

Indicator description

Percentage of school leavers with at least an NCEA Level 3 qualification or equivalent.¹

Why attaining NCEA Level 3 is important

The National Certificate of Educational Achievement Level 3 (NCEA Level 3) is the final stage of senior secondary education and serves as a foundation for further study and/or employment. NCEA Level 3, as with all levels of NCEA, encompasses a wide range of learning. Students can attain credits through internal and external assessment, and they can accumulate these credits both within and across years.

Achieving NCEA Level 3 is only one component of attaining University Entrance (UE). UE is the minimum requirement to go to a New Zealand university. Attainment of UE standard includes attainment of the UE award and attainment of UE standard from assessments outside the New Zealand Qualifications Framework (NZQF). Examples of alternative assessments are: International Baccalaureate, Cambridge International exams and Accelerated Christian Education.

The attainment of a senior secondary school qualification is linked to labour force status and incomes. Every year around 60,000 young people leave school and face choices about what to do next. Not being in employment, further education, or training (NEET) affects 17% to 19% of school leavers each year in the first seven years after leaving school (Scott 2018).

Scott also found the earnings of students who attain the UE standard and forgo employment initially for tertiary study, overtake the earnings of all their lesser-qualified peer groups five years after leaving school. By year 7, the average earnings for the UE standard group is 28% higher than those who leave school with only NCEA Level 2.

In 2019, on average, New Zealanders with a bachelor's degree earned 27% more than their counterparts with only a senior secondary education, the earning advantage increases to 52% for those with a master's or doctoral degree. On average across the OECD these differences are 43% for a bachelor's degree and 87% for a master's or doctoral degree. (OECD, 2021).

¹ Equivalent attainment includes attainment of NCEA Level 3 standard from assessments outside the New Zealand Qualifications Framework. Examples of alternative assessments are: International Baccalaureate, Cambridge International exams and Accelerated Christian Education.

How are we going

In 2024, 55.5% (37,397) of school leavers attained NCEA Level 3 or above, an increase of 2.7 percentage points (52.8% in 2023). Attainment of NCEA Level 3 peaked in 2020 at 60.7% and has decreased by 5.2 percentage points since then (see Figure 1).

A change in the requirements for UE standard came into effect in 2014. Since 2014 students need to attain NCEA Level 3 and meet subject requirements in approved UE subjects. This caused a decrease in the proportion of school leavers who attained UE standard between 2013 and 2014, even though the proportion of school leavers with NCEA Level 3 increased.

In 2024, 1.3% of leavers with NCEA Level 3 or above attained New Zealand Scholarship or a NZQF qualification at Level 4 or higher, while 14.2 % of leavers had their NCEA Level 3 qualification endorsed with Excellence, 26.6% with Merit, and 63.4% achieved NCEA Level 3 without endorsement.

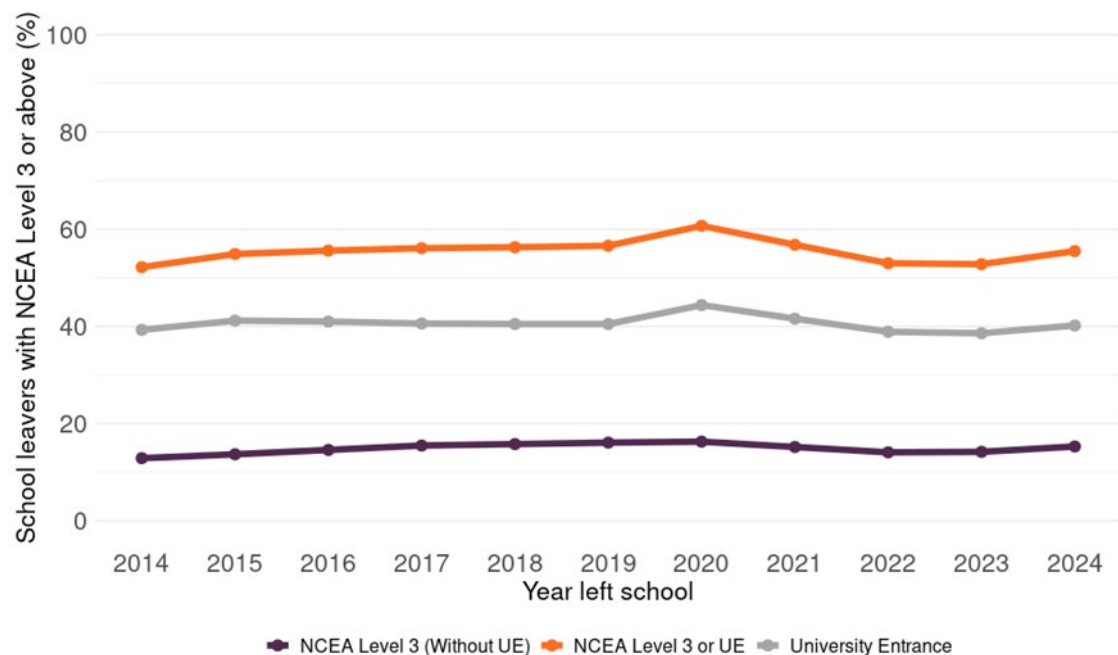
Of the 2024 leavers with NCEA Level 3 or above, 4.0% had attained a Year 13 equivalent attainment such as International Baccalaureate, Cambridge International or another overseas award as their highest qualification.

In 2024, female (59.5%) school leavers were more likely to attain NCEA Level 3 or above male (51.6%) leavers.

Asian (72.4%) school leavers had the highest attainment rates for NCEA Level 3 or above, followed by European/Pākehā (56.9%), Pacific (49.5%), and Māori (37.1%).

Schools where students have fewer barriers to achievement have higher attainment rates. In 2024, 83.8% of leavers from schools where students have the fewest barriers attained NCEA Level 2 or above compared to 35.1% of leavers from schools where students have the most barriers.

Figure 1: The attainment rate for NCEA Level 3 or above increased in 2024

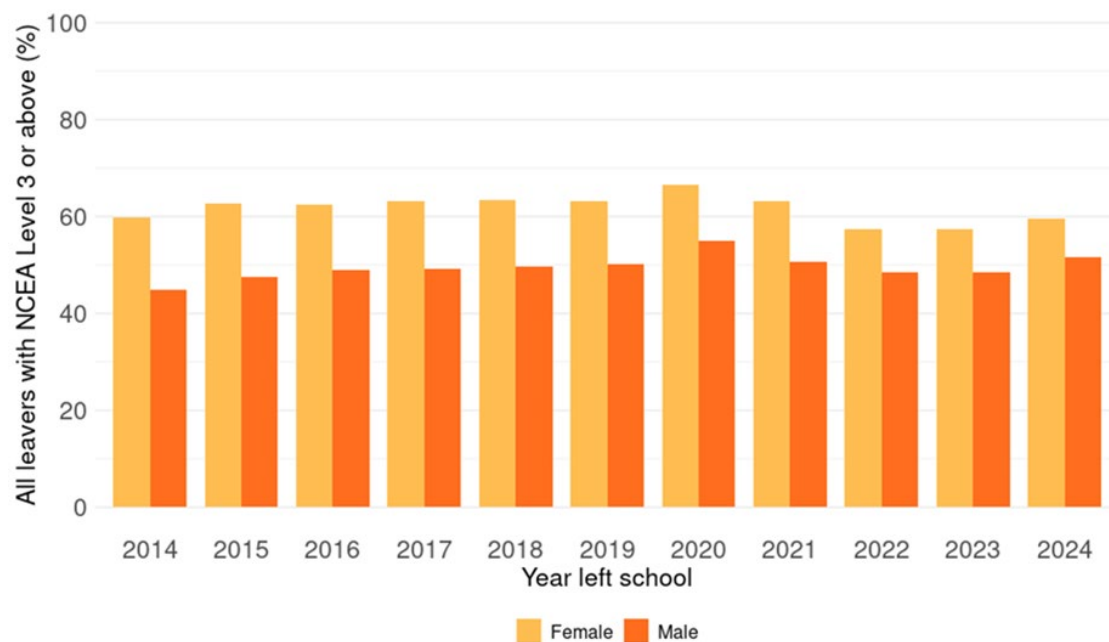


Gender

Since 2014, NCEA Level 3 or above attainment has been higher for female school leavers as shown in Figure 2.

In 2024, 59.5% of female leavers attained NCEA Level 3 or above compared to 51.6% of male leavers. This is an increase of 2.1 percentage points for female leavers and an increase of 3.2 percentage points for male leavers since 2023. This decreased the gender gap from 9.0 percentage points in 2023 to 7.9 percentage points in 2024.

Figure 2: The gender gap in leavers' attainment of NCEA Level 3 or above is decreasing over time



Socioeconomic barriers²

At a system level, schools where students experience more socioeconomic barriers to achievement have lower NCEA Level 3 or above attainment rates and a higher variability of attainment rates within the School Equity Index Bands. This indicates that there is an association between NCEA Level 3 or above attainment rates and socioeconomic background.

In 2024, schools where students have fewest barriers to achievement had an NCEA Level 3 attainment rate of 84.0 percentage points, and those where students have the most barriers to achievement had an attainment rate of 36.2 percentage points.

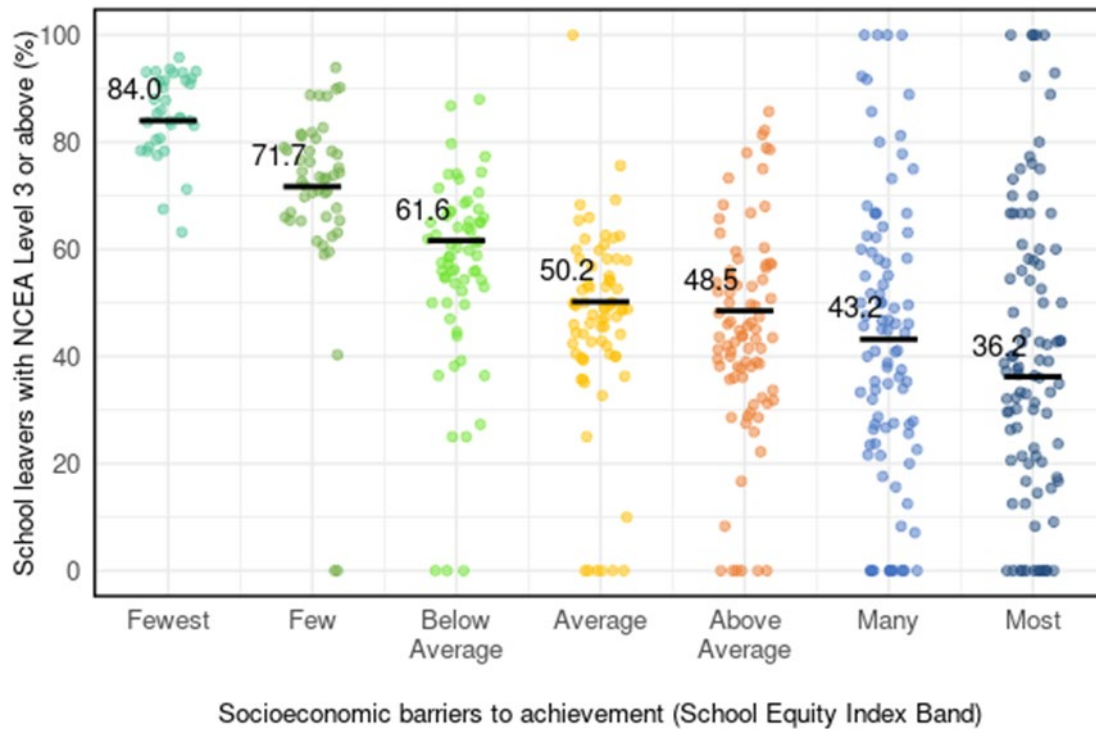
Figure 3 shows the distribution of NCEA Level 3 or above attainment rates for school leavers in 2024, by School Equity Index Band. There is variation in the percentage of school leavers attaining NCEA Level 3 or above among schools within each School Equity Index Band. This variation from the average increases with barriers to achievement.

² For more information about the School Equity Index Groups and Bands see the section at the end of this indicator report.



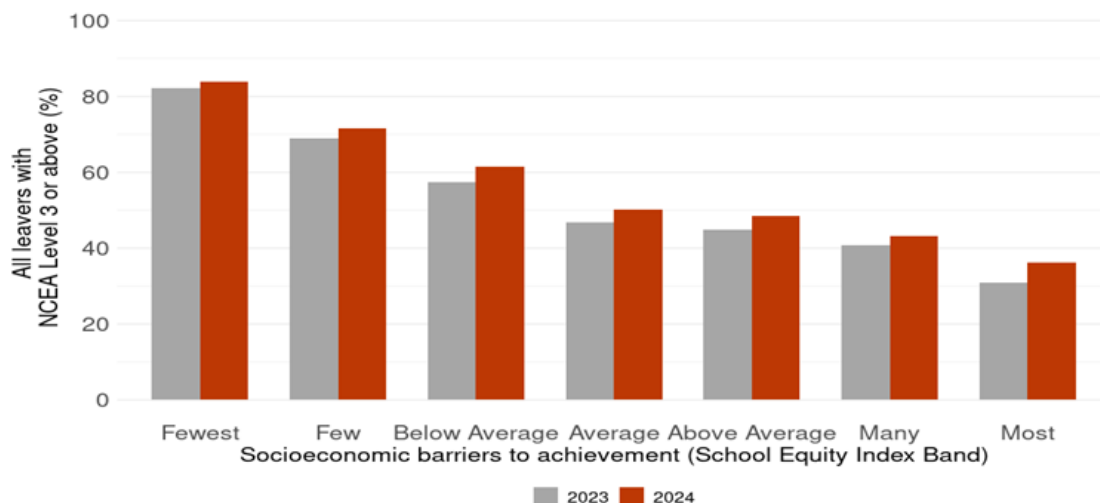
Schools with fewest barriers to achievement have less school-to-school variation from the average, as shown by the dots that are scattered closer to the band average. Schools with more barriers to achievement have higher between school variations in attainment rates. Within each band, there are schools that have higher attainment rates while others have disproportionately low attainment rates.

Figure 3: The proportion of school leavers with NCEA Level 3 or above varies between schools within each School Equity Index Band



Compared to 2023, in 2024 across every band, a higher proportion of school leavers left school with NCEA Level 3 or above as shown in Figure 4. The highest increase in attainment was in schools where students have the most barriers to achievement where attainment increased from 31.0% in 2023 to 36.2% in 2024.

Figure 4: From 2023 to 2024 school leavers the proportion of school leavers attaining NCEA Level 3 or above has increased in every School Equity Index Band



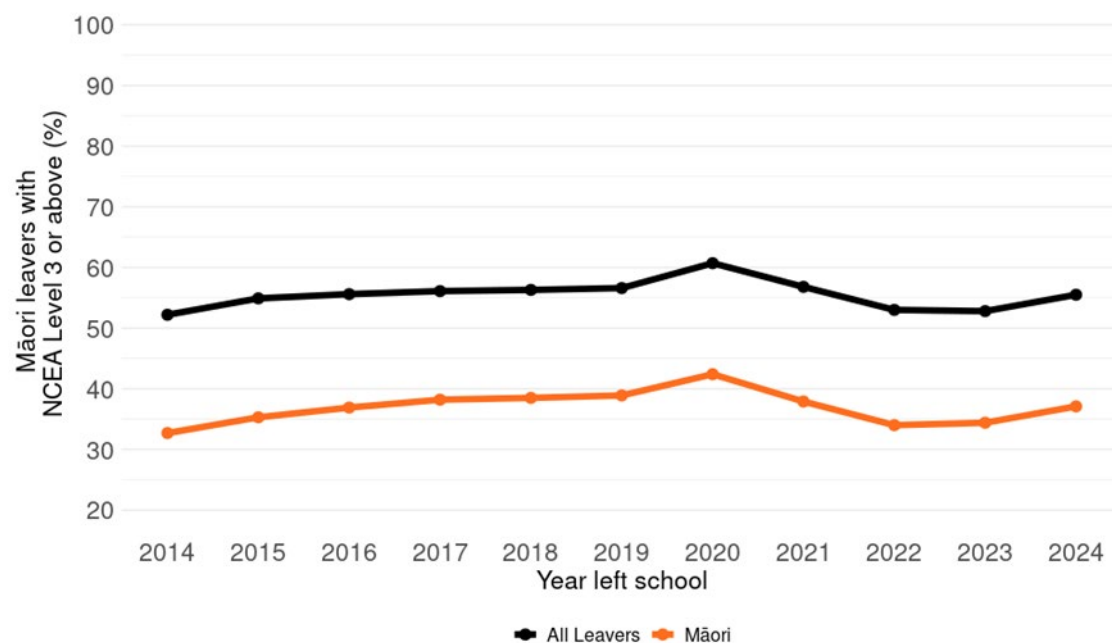
Ethnicity³

Compared to 2023 the proportion of school leavers attaining NCEA Level 3 or above in 2024 was varied for all ethnic groupings. Māori, Pacific and European/Pākehā attainment rates increased while rates for Asian leavers decreased.

Māori school leavers

In 2024, 6,259 Māori school leavers (37.1%) attained NCEA Level 3 or above, as shown in Figure 5. Between 2020 (the peak attainment for Māori leavers) and 2024, the attainment rate for NCEA Level 3 decreased by 5.3 percentage points. Between 2019 (the most recent year prior to Covid-19) and 2024, the attainment rate decreased by 1.8 percentage points. The gap in NCEA Level 3 attainment rates between Māori school leavers and for all school leavers decreased in 2024 to 18.4 percentage points, unchanged from 2023.

Figure 5: Māori school leavers attainment of NCEA Level 3 or above increased in 2024

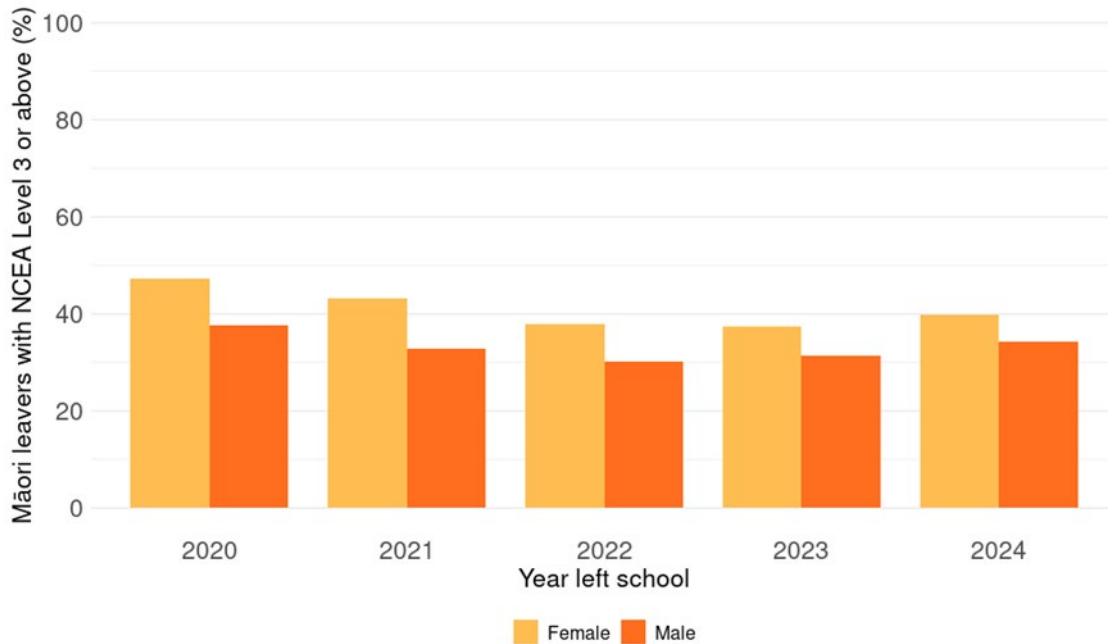


In 2024, 39.9 % of Māori female school leavers attained NCEA Level 3 or above compared to 34.4% of Māori male school leavers; up 2.5 and 3.0 percentage points from 2023 for female and male school leavers respectively. Since 2020, Māori female leavers had higher NCEA Level 3 attainment compared to Māori male leavers as shown in Figure 6. The gap in NCEA Level 3 attainment rates between females and males has decreased from 9.6 percentage points in 2020, to 6.0 percentage points in 2023 and 5.5 percentage points in 2024.

³ Total response ethnicity counts students who identify with more than one ethnic group in each of these ethnic groups. For the New Zealand total, individuals are counted only once.

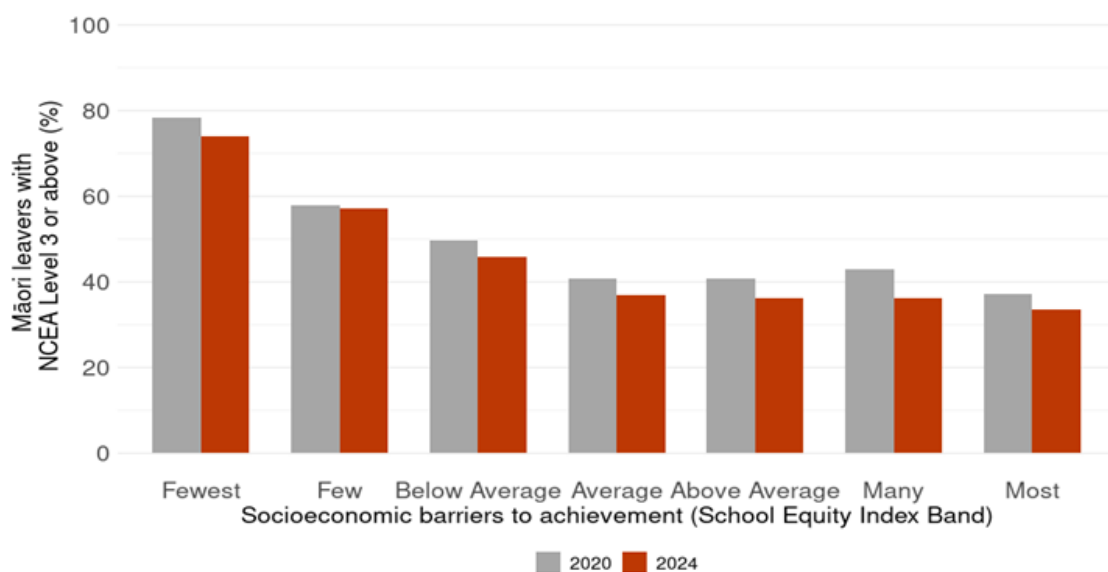


Figure 6: Māori female school leavers were more likely to attain NCEA Level 3 or above



Māori school leavers from schools where students have fewer barriers to achievement are more likely to attain NCEA Level 3 or above as shown in Figure 7. In 2024, 73.9% of Māori leavers from schools where students have fewest barriers to achievement attained NCEA Level 3 compared to 33.5% of Māori leavers from schools where students have the most barriers to achievement. The NCEA Level 3 or above attainment gap between school leavers from schools where students have fewest barriers to achievement and those from schools where students have the most barriers to achievement has become wider over time: from 41.1% in 2020 to 47.0% in 2023 and 40.3% in 2024.

Figure 7: Since 2020, the proportion of Māori school leavers with NCEA Level 3 or above has decreased in all School Equity Index Bands



Māori and language of learning⁴

Māori predominantly learning in te reo Māori

Of the 16,861 ākonga Māori who left school in 2024, 5% (835 Māori school leavers) were predominantly learning in te reo Māori, an increase of 74.7% since 2014 (478 Māori school leavers in 2014).

Note that when looking at statistics based on small populations, such as the small number of school leavers learning in te reo Māori, a small change in numbers can result in a relatively large change in the proportions and therefore relatively large fluctuations from year to year.

In 2024, 58.8% of Māori school leavers who were predominantly learning in te reo Māori attained NCEA Level 3 or above, up 6.7 percentage points from 2023.

The gap in NCEA Level 3 attainment rates between Māori school leavers who were predominantly learning in te reo Māori and all school leavers increased to 3.3 percentage points in 2024 (58.8% and 55.5% respectively). In the last 10 years the difference has been as large as 6.5 percentage points (in 2018) and as low as 0.7 percentage points (in 2023). This gap is driven by generally higher attainment rates for Māori leavers who were learning in te reo Māori compared to the rates for all leavers.

Māori predominantly learning in English

The NCEA Level 3 or above attainment rate for Māori school leavers who were predominantly learning in English was 36%, up 2.6 percentage points from 2023.

The gap in NCEA Level 3 attainment rates between Māori school leavers who were predominantly learning in English and all school leavers increased to 19.5 percentage points in 2024 from 19.4 percentage points in 2023.

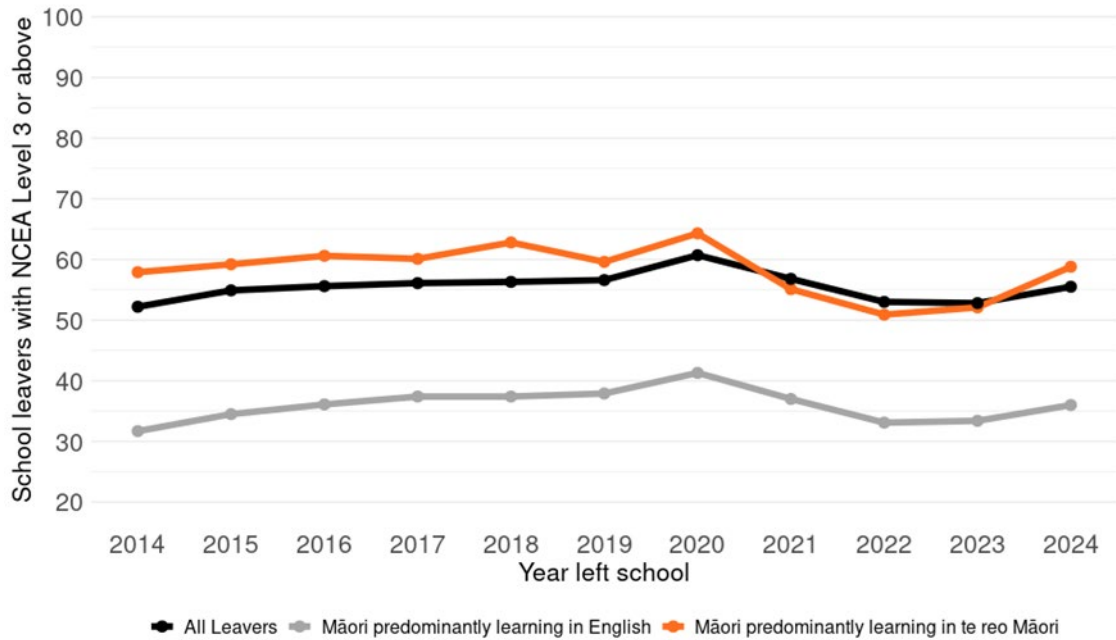
Figure 8 shows that attainment of NCEA Level 3 or above for school leavers predominantly learning in te reo Māori was comparable to all leavers' attainment across 2014 to 2024. In contrast, Māori school leavers predominantly learning in English consistently had lower attainment rates over the same period.

In 2024, Māori leavers predominantly learning in te reo Māori had higher attainment of NCEA Level 3 or above than national average for all leavers. This is consistent with the findings by Smith et. al (2020) that connection with identity, language and culture has large effects on NCEA outcomes for ākonga Māori as shown by higher attainment for ākonga Māori learning in te reo Māori.

⁴ The predominant language of learning is the one that school leavers are learning in at least 51% of the time.



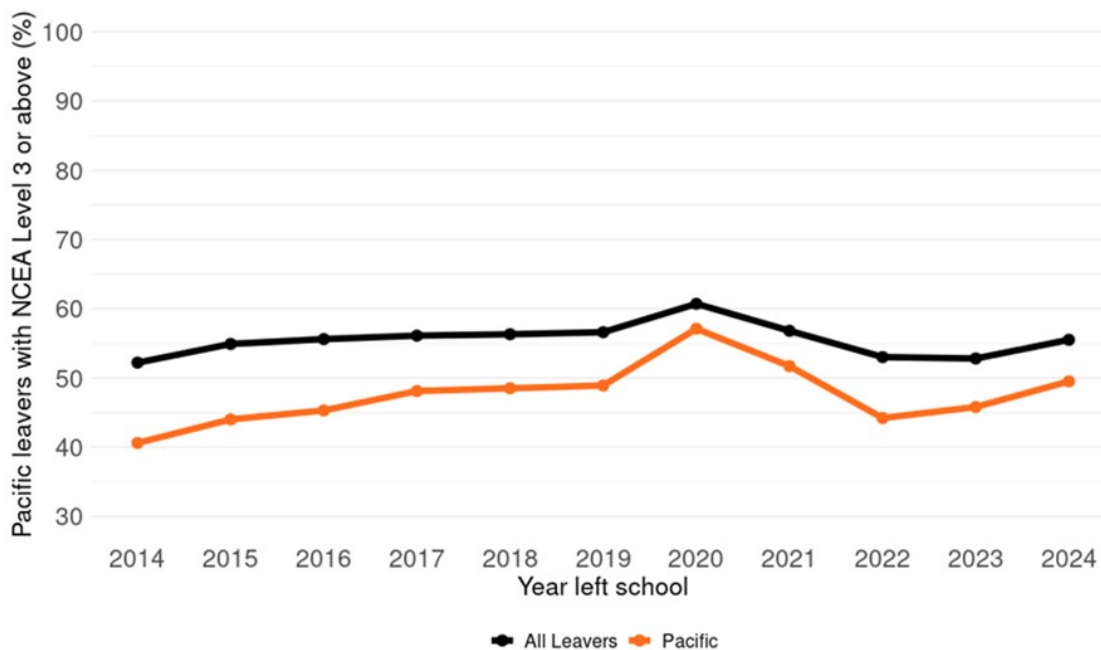
Figure 8: A higher proportion of Māori school leavers predominantly learning in te reo Māori attained NCEA Level 3 or above



Pacific school leavers

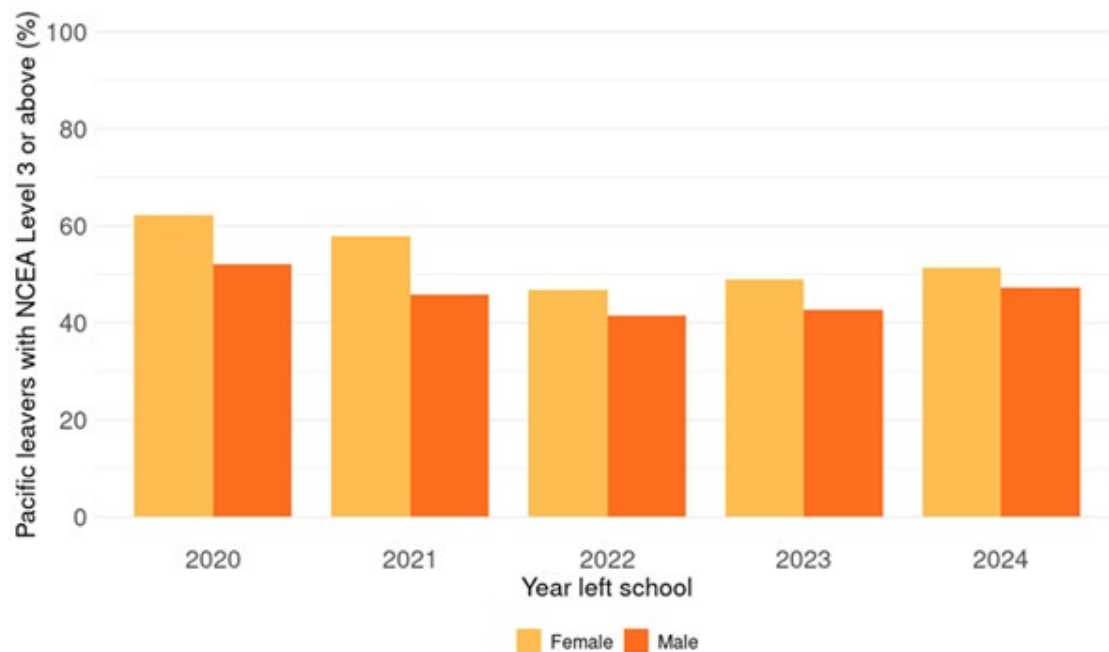
In 2024 4,265 (49.5%) of Pacific school leavers attained NCEA Level 3 or above, up 3.7 percentage points from 2023. As shown in Figure 9, the NCEA Level 3 or above attainment rates for Pacific school leavers has been lower than the national average since 2014. Between 2020 (the peak attainment) and 2024, the rate decreased by 7.6 percentage points. Between 2019 (the most recent year prior to Covid-19) and 2024 the rate increased by 0.6 percentage points.

Figure 9: Pacific school leavers attainment of NCEA Level 3 or above increased in 2024



In 2024, 51.5% of Pacific female school leavers attained NCEA Level 3 or above compared to 47.4% of Pacific male school leavers, up 2.6 and 4.7 percentage points from 2023 for Pacific female and male school leavers respectively. The gap in NCEA Level 3 attainment rates between females and males has decreased from 10.2% in 2020, to 6.2% in 2023 and 4.1% in 2024. As shown in Figure 10, the attainment rates for females are higher than the rates for males over the period from 2020 to 2024.

Figure 10: The gap in attainment between female and male Pacific school leavers with NCEA Level 3 or above decreased in 2024

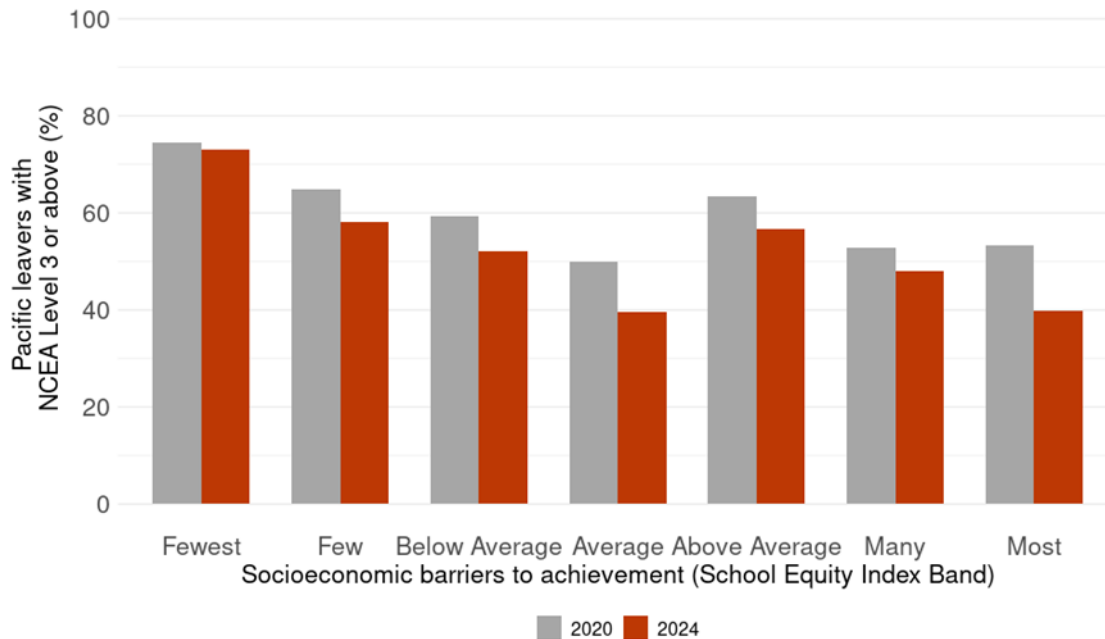


Pacific school leavers from schools with fewer barriers to achievement are more likely to attain NCEA Level 3 or above. In 2024, 73.1% of Pacific leavers from schools where learners have fewest barriers to achievement attained NCEA Level 3 compared to 39.8% of Pacific leavers from schools where learners have the most barriers to achievement. Across all School Equity Index Bands, NCEA Level 3 or above attainment in 2024 was lower than in 2020 as shown in Figure 11.

While the 5-year range from 2020 to 2024 shows that attainment of NCEA Level 3 or above has declined from 2020 to 2024, Figure 11 also shows that these declines have been the highest for leavers in schools where learners have the most barriers to achievement. Between 2020 and 2024, the attainment rate for Pacific leavers from schools where learners have most barriers decreased by 13.4 percentage points compared to 1.5 percentage points decrease for Pacific leavers from schools where learners have fewest barriers.



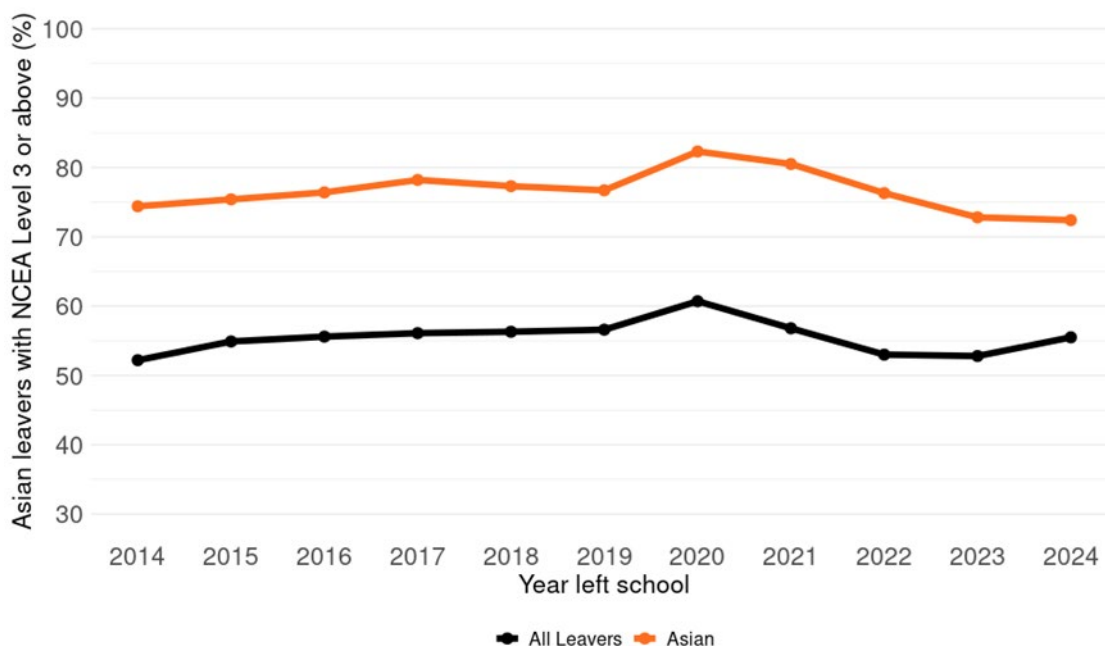
Figure 11: Since 2020, Pacific school leavers' attainment of NCEA Level 3 or above has decreased in all School Equity Index Bands



Asian school leavers

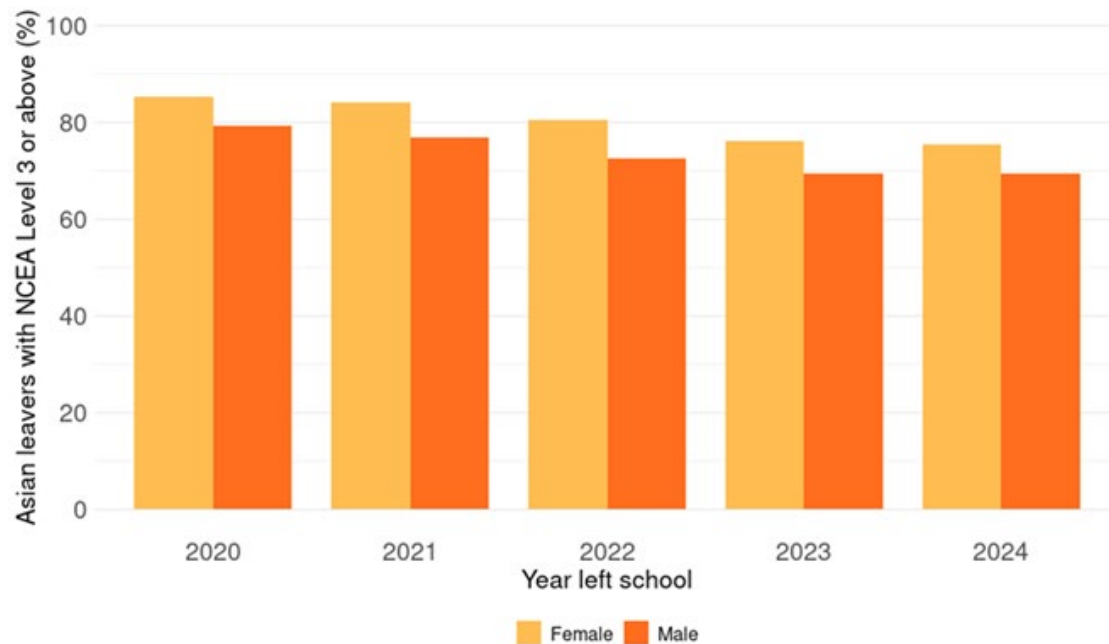
School leavers who identify with an Asian ethnicity have the highest NCEA Level 3 or above attainment rate as shown in Figure 12. The attainment rate for Asian leavers is stable with smaller fluctuations. In 2024, 72.4% of Asian school leavers attained NCEA Level 3 or above, down 0.4 percentage points from 2023. Between 2020 (the peak attainment) and 2024, the rate decreased by 9.9 percentage points. Between 2019 (the most recent year prior to Covid-19) and 2024, the rate decreased by 4.3 percentage points.

Figure 12: A high proportion of Asian school leavers attained NCEA Level 3 or above



In 2024, 75.5% of Asian female school leavers attained NCEA Level 3 or above compared to 69.5% of Asian male school leavers. While these rates are high, they are among some of the lowest attainment rates for Asian females and Asian males since 2014. Female Asian leavers had higher NCEA Level 3 or above attainment rates compared to Asian male leavers as shown in Figure 13. The gap in NCEA Level 3 or above attainment rates between Asian females and males remains relatively stable at around 6 percentage points.

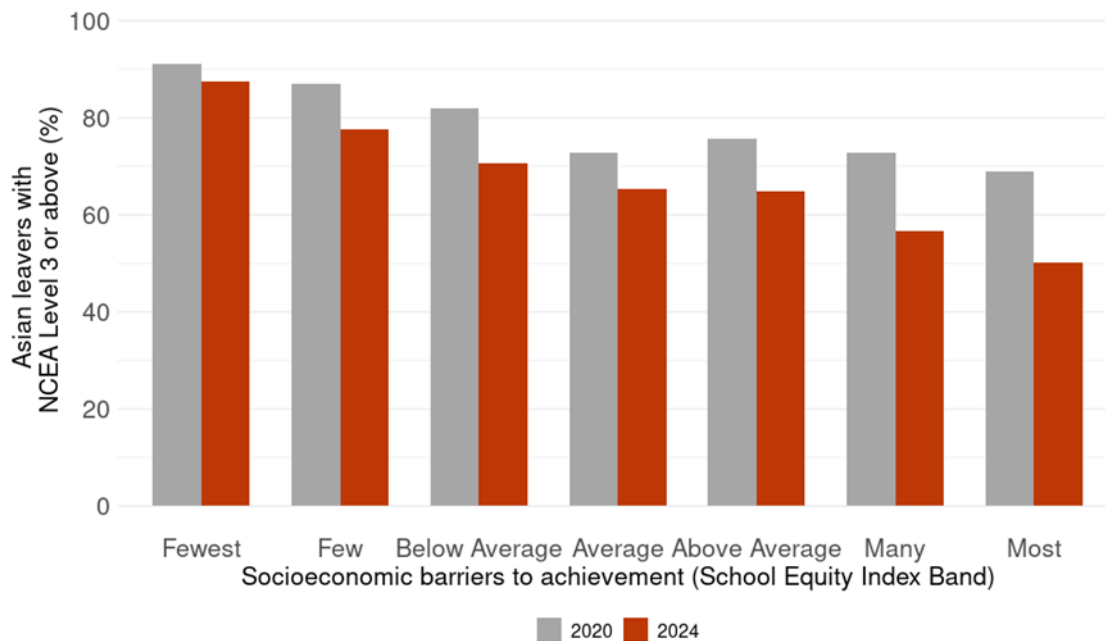
Figure 13: Asian female school leavers are more likely to attain NCEA Level 3 or above



The gradient effect between socioeconomic barriers and school leavers attainment of NCEA Level 3 or above is smaller for Asian school leavers as shown in Figure 14. In 2024, Asian school leavers from schools where students have fewest barriers to achievement attained NCEA Level 3 or above the highest attainment 87.4%. However, the NCEA Level 3 or above attainment rate for Asian school leavers is higher than the national average in all bands. Asian school leavers from schools where students have the most barriers to achievement had an attainment rate of 50.2% which is 14.0 percentage points higher than the national average for 2024.



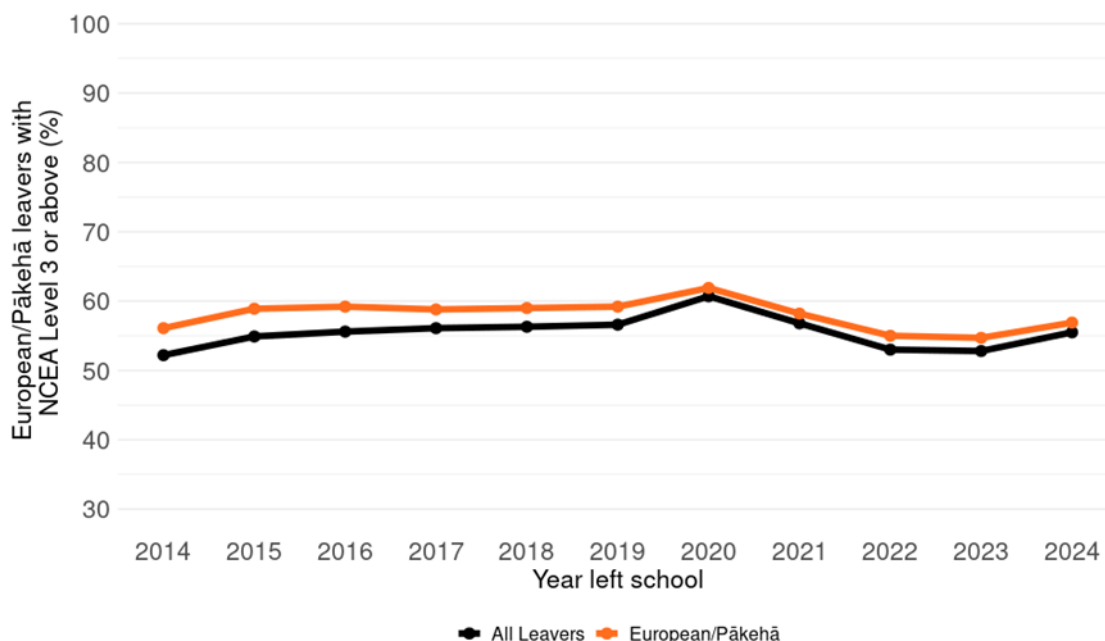
Figure 14: Since 2020 the proportion of Asian school leavers with NCEA Level 3 or above has decreased in all School Equity Index Bands



European/Pākehā school leavers

In 2024, 56.9% of European/Pākehā school leavers attained NCEA Level 3 or above, up 2.2 percentage points from 2023. Between 2020 (the peak attainment) and 2024, the rate decreased by 5.0 percentage points. Between 2019 (the most recent year prior to Covid-19) and 2024, the rate decreased by 2.3 percentage points (see Figure 15).

Figure 15: European/Pākehā school leavers attainment of NCEA Level 3 or above increased in 2024



In 2024, 61.5% of European/Pākehā female school leavers attained NCEA Level 3 or above compared to 52.4% of European/Pākehā male school leavers. The gap in NCEA Level 3 attainment rates between European/Pākehā females and males decreased from 14 percentage points in 2020, to 11.1 percentage points in 2023 and 9.1 percentage points in 2024 (see Figure 16).

A higher proportion of European/Pākehā school leavers from schools where students have fewer barriers to achievement attained NCEA Level 3 or above as shown in Figure 17. In 2024, 84.5% of European/Pākehā from schools where students have fewest barriers to achievement attained NCEA Level 3 or above compared to 32.2% of European/Pākehā from schools where students have the most barriers to achievement.

Figure 16: The gender gap for European/Pākehā school leavers with NCEA Level 3 or above has decreased

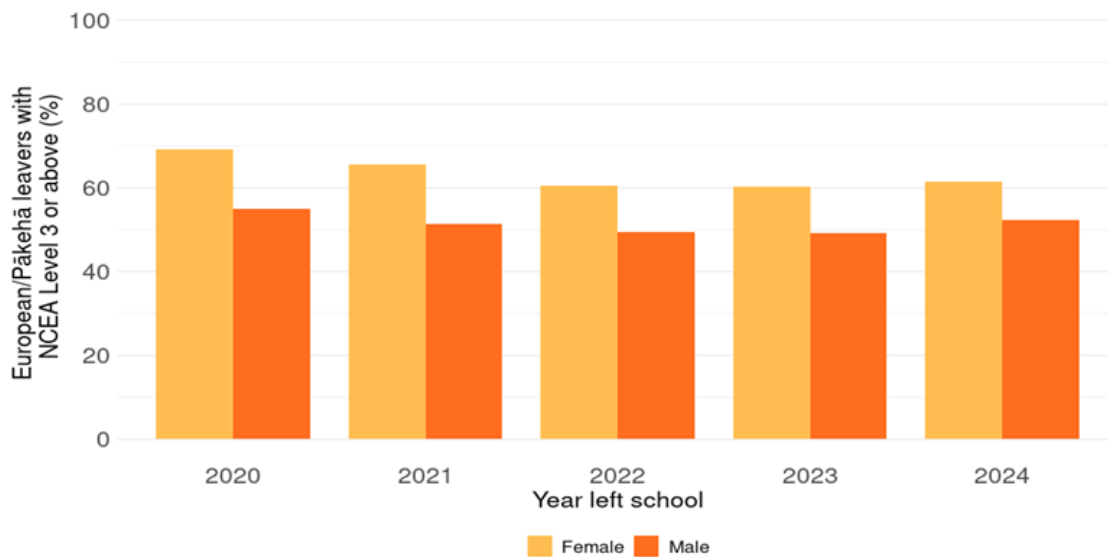
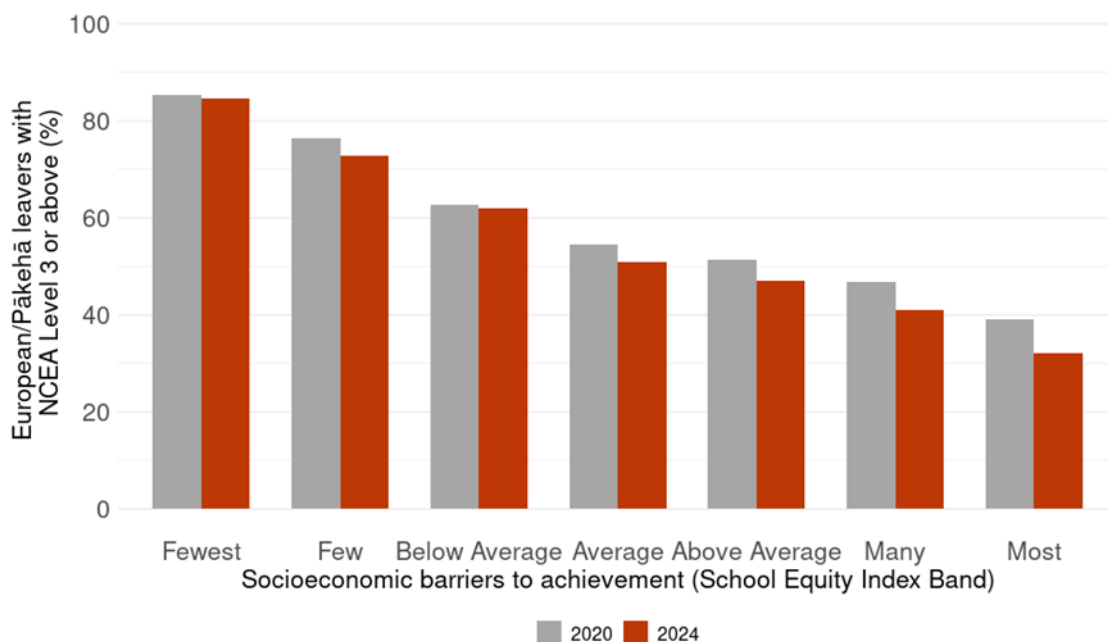


Figure 17: Since 2020 the proportion of European/Pākehā school leavers with NCEA Level 3 or above has decreased



University Entrance Standard

Attainment of the UE standard was higher in schools where students experience low barriers to achievement, as shown in Figure 18. In 2024, 40.2% of all school leavers attained UE Standard, a 1.6 percentage points increase from 2023 (38.6%).

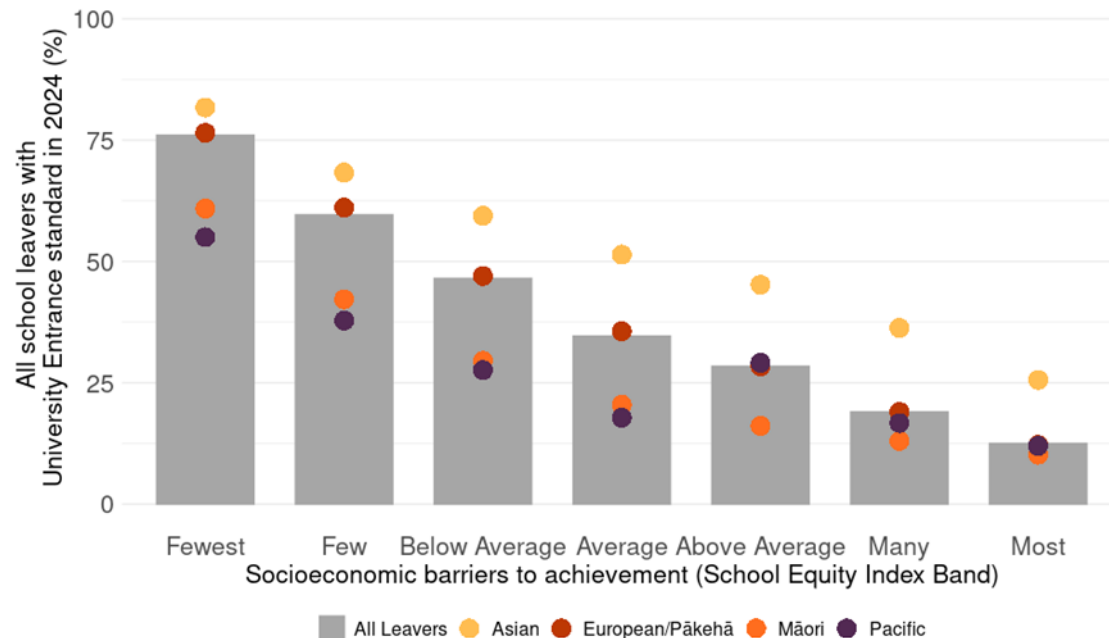
In 2024, UE Standard was attained by 19.4% of Māori school leavers overall. In schools where students have fewest barriers to achievement, 60.9% of Māori leavers attained UE, compared to 10.2% of Māori leavers from schools where students have the most barriers to achievement.

UE Standard was attained by 24.3% of Pacific school leavers overall. In schools where students have fewest barriers to achievement, 55.0% of Pacific school leavers attained UE, compared to 12.0% from schools where students have the most barriers to achievement.

Asian leavers' had the highest proportion attaining UE Standard, with 60.9% of Asian school leavers attaining UE standard overall. In schools where students have fewest barriers to achievement, 81.7% of Asian school leavers attained UE, compared to 25.6% from schools where students have the most barriers to achievement.

For European/Pākehā school leavers, 43% attained UE standard overall. In schools where students have fewest barriers to achievement, 76.5% of European/Pākehā school leavers attained UE, compared to 12.3% from schools where students have the most barriers to achievement.

Figure 18: All ethnic groups experience a gradient of attainment of UE standard across School Equity Index Bands in 2024



About School Equity Index reporting

The Ministry has developed a new measure for reporting on socioeconomic trends in education statistics, these new measures are called School Equity Index Bands and Groups, derived from the Schooling Equity Index Number. These measures estimate the extent to which, on average, students at a school face socioeconomic barriers that could get in the way of their school achievement.

There are seven School Equity Index Bands, each containing approximately the same number of schools. Schools are placed into a band based on their School Equity Index Number. There are three School Equity Index Groups formed by collapsing the seven School Equity Index Bands as indicated in the following diagram. More information on this reporting method can be found on the Ministry's Education Counts website [here](#).

Schooling Equity Index Number:



School Equity Index Band:

Fewest	Few	Below Average	Average	Above Average	Many	Most

Socioeconomic barriers to achievement

School Equity Index Group:

Fewer	Moderate	More

Socioeconomic barriers to achievement

Where to find out more

To obtain information about other forms of student disengagement consider indicators:

- [Tracked Year 11 cohort - Attainment timeframes for Level 2 certificate](#)
- [School leaver pathways](#)

References

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